

Sales Training — Session 33

Clean the Boat.

The Squid Ink Principle.

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WHAT THIS SESSION IS Most calls don't fail because the rep said the wrong thing — they fail because the rep let the previous call colour the current one. This session is about mindset hygiene between calls: why buyers spray defensive lies, why there is no "silver bullet" line that closes them anyway, and the simple rituals that protect the rep's mental edge across a full day on the phones.

1. The selective-hearing trap — why "can you take more work?" backfires

A rep opens the call with "Hi, are you able to take on more work right now?" The buyer's brain hears something different: "this person has a job for me." They reply enthusiastically — "yes, absolutely, I can take more on." The rep then explains they're calling about SEO. The buyer's brain re-parses the call, realises they're being sold to, and within ten seconds switches to "actually I'm flat-out booked, three months out, can't take a thing."

This isn't the buyer being deceptive. It's selective hearing. They heard what they wanted to hear in the opening seconds, committed to it out loud, and then had to reverse-engineer a retreat once they realised the actual context of the call. The rep didn't say anything wrong — they just opened with a sentence the buyer could misinterpret in a self-serving direction.

"They didn't hear you when you first spoke. They were thinking you were a client with a job for them. Now they realise they're being sold to — and they're trying to back out of what they just said."

The fix is straightforward: name the call's purpose clearly in the first sentence. "Hi, this is Phil from Marketing Sweet — I'm calling about your SEO traffic, not about a job." The line costs nothing and removes the selective-hearing window entirely. The buyer can't misparse a sentence that's already named itself.

2. There is no silver bullet — the 147-kilowatt rule

A reset on what's actually possible in a sales call. The reps in the room kept asking for the magic line — the perfect phrase that would close the buyer who said "I'm not interested." That line doesn't exist. Sales doesn't work like that, and chasing it produces the exact anxiety it claims to fix.

Corie offered a clean mental model. A standard Toyota 86 produces 147 kilowatts. That's it. You can rev the engine, polish the paint, install a spoiler — the engine still produces 147 kilowatts. What you CAN do is produce less. Push the throttle too softly. Drive in the wrong gear. Forget to service it. The engine is operating at its ceiling already. There's no "more" to extract from it — there's only "less" to give away.

Sales works the same way. The rep is the 147kW engine. They're already at the ceiling of what's persuadable in any given call. What they can do is reduce performance — by saying dumb things, by sounding desperate, by abandoning the process to chase a hunch. The job isn't to be the world's greatest closer. The job is to be the boringly reliable Toyota: run the process every time, don't blow yourself up, keep moving.

"You're 147 kilowatts. You can't get any more out of it. The only thing you can do is make it produce less by saying dumb things. The job is to not blow the engine up."

3. The squid ink principle — what buyers' lies actually are

The central metaphor of the session. When a squid is attacked, it sprays ink — not to harm the predator, but to confuse the situation and escape. Cold-called buyers do exactly the same thing. "I'm not interested." "I'm too busy." "I'm already with someone good." "Send me an email." None of those statements are necessarily true. They're ink — defensive smoke designed to end the call quickly so the buyer can get back to their day.

This reframe matters because it removes the rep's moral outrage. The buyer isn't being a bad person. They're doing what humans do when an unknown stranger calls them up trying to sell something. The reps who internalise this stop taking the lies personally and stop trying to argue with them. The reps who don't internalise it carry frustration from call to call — and the frustration leaks into the next call's tone.

"Buyers spray ink. It's not because they're evil — it's human nature. Your job is to be a calm squid fisherman, not to take it personally that the boat keeps getting inked."

Two practical implications. First, when a buyer says "I'm too busy," the rep should mentally label it ink and respond to what they think might be the real situation — not the literal claim. Second, when the rep catches themselves emotionally rattled by a call, they should mentally hose the boat down before dialling the next one. The ink only damages the boat if it's left to dry.

4. The two opposite lies — "I can't" and "I'll buy everything"

Buyers lie in two opposite directions, and reps need to recognise both. The first lie is the under-statement: "I can't take more work, I'm flat-out busy, no need for marketing." That's the classic defensive ink — almost no business in history has genuinely turned away free customers when offered. The default assumption when this line lands is "this is a deflection, not a fact."

The second lie is the over-statement: "I've got ten businesses, I want SEO for all of them, I'll spend whatever it takes." That sounds like a dream call — and that's exactly why it's dangerous. Almost no buyer actually closes on ten businesses in one go. The over-statement is bait: the buyer is using the size of the opportunity to extract concessions, then

will quietly walk when the negotiation tightens. Reps who get excited by the over-statement get played.

"The under-statement is 'I'm not interested.' The over-statement is 'I'll buy everything.' Both are lies. The discipline is the same response either way: stick to the process. Don't get excited. Sell one thing properly."

The correct counter to the over-statement: "With all due respect, I'd rather prove myself on one campaign first. Pick the business you most want results for — let's do that one really well, and then talk about the rest." The rep loses nothing — if the buyer was genuine, they'll happily start with one. If they were bluffing, the bluff collapses immediately.

5. Clean the boat — mindset hygiene between calls

The most practical move of the session. A rep takes 30 calls in a day. Most of them are ink. Without a deliberate cleaning ritual, the ink accumulates — frustration from call seven leaks into call eight, leaks into call nine, and by call twenty the rep is talking to every buyer as though they've already been lied to. The buyer hears it, and the day collapses.

The fix is to clean the boat. Practical rituals:

- After a particularly bad call, stand up. Walk to the kitchen, get a glass of water, come back. The physical reset interrupts the mental loop.
- Mid-morning and mid-afternoon, take a short walk outside the office. Three minutes is enough. The brain resets faster than the rep expects.
- When the brain starts looping on "I should have said X" — acknowledge the loop, write the thought down (it might be useful), then close it. The loop only ends when the thought is captured.
- Avoid the temptation to vent at colleagues mid-day. Venting reinforces the frustration rather than discharging it. Vent at the end of the day, when it's safe to. During the day, hose the boat down and dial again.

"Hose the boat down. Get the ink off. Don't let day eight of negativity build up on the boat — the value of the boat goes down. Treat your mind as the boat. Care for it."

6. Sales is time travel — pattern recognition compounds

A different angle on what the rep is actually doing on the phones. Most reps treat each call as a fresh, isolated event. A more useful frame: each call is another data point in a pattern-recognition game. The rep who notices that 8 of the last 10 buyers said "I'm too busy" between Wednesday and Friday afternoons can adjust — change the call's framing, lead with a different question, schedule differently.

Time travel — in the literal sense the session offered — is the privilege of carrying knowledge from one round of the same conversation into the next. A rep on call number 200 of a six-month tenure has, effectively, time-travelled through 200 instances of the same kind

of dialogue. They've seen which openings get ink and which get attention. They know which objection-handlers actually work in this specific market segment. That accumulated knowledge is the rep's edge — and it only accumulates if the rep is paying attention.

"You're not making 50 random calls. You're running the same conversation 50 times with different humans. You're a time traveller. Use the knowledge you came back with."

Practical move: keep a one-page running pattern log. Three columns — "opening line / buyer reaction / what worked." After two weeks, the rep will see patterns nobody else on the team has noticed. After two months, those patterns are the rep's competitive advantage.

7. Chase the deal. Never chase the customer.

A subtle but important distinction. The deal exists — there are buyers out there who genuinely need what the agency sells, and one of them will close this week. The rep's job is to keep dialling until they find that buyer. The deal is the thing being chased.

The customer — the specific person on the other end of the current call — is not the thing being chased. If they're not the buyer, the rep should move on quickly and find one who is. Reps who chase individual customers — who stay on dead calls hoping to convert the unconvertible, who burn an hour negotiating with a tyre-kicker — are eating into the time they need to find the actual buyer. The deal is one phone call away. It's just not THIS phone call.

"You chase the deal. You never chase the customer. The customer either qualifies or they don't. The deal is somewhere — you don't know which phone number it's hiding in, but it's there. Keep dialling."

This is the abundance frame applied at the call level. Walking away from a dead call isn't giving up — it's freeing time for the live one. The reps who close the most volume aren't the ones with the highest conversion per call; they're the ones who recognise dead calls fastest and move to the next dial.

8. The cheeky callback — naming the lie with humour

A specific verbal move for when the buyer's selective hearing has tripped them up — they said yes at the start, then panicked and said no. Rather than letting it slide or pushing back hard, the rep can use humour to call it out gently. Something like: "Hang on — when we started talking, you said you could take more work. Now you're booked out solid. Did I just do that to you? Did I just book you out by being amazing on the phone? I'm going to need a finder's fee for the work I just sent you."

Done right, the line does three things at once. It names the contradiction without accusing the buyer of lying. It uses humour to keep the tone light. And it gives the buyer a gentle way back into the conversation if they want it — most buyers, faced with the gentle call-out, will laugh, soften, and admit that the opportunity isn't as closed as they made it sound.

"What happened? Did you just book out because of me? You said you could take more work and now you're flat out. That's a pretty good sales pitch I just did."

The line only works with warm energy. Delivered coldly, it lands as accusatory. Delivered with a smile in the voice, it lands as playful — and playful is what disarms the buyer who's just told a defensive lie. The rep should practise this verbatim, with tone, before using it on a live call.

9. Time as currency — the 5-minute frame (recap)

A recap of a principle from earlier sessions, applied again here. When the rep asks for time, the buyer mentally translates the duration into dollars. Half an hour from a stranger on a cold call reads as "\$30,000 of my time." An hour reads as "a million dollars of my time." Five minutes reads as "50 cents." The brain literally prices the ask before deciding whether to grant it.

Hence the discipline: always quote the meeting as 5 minutes, or at the absolute longest 10. "I've got something interesting I want to show you — it'll only take five minutes." Not because the meeting will only take five minutes (it often won't) but because the buyer needs to feel the commitment is small enough to be safe. Once they're in the meeting and engaged, they'll happily spend an hour. The trick is getting them in, and the five-minute frame is what unlocks that.

"Half an hour is \$30k. An hour is a million. Five minutes is 50 cents. When you ask for time, ask in the right currency."

10. Honesty, loyalty, integrity — the anchor principles

Beneath all the tactics, the session named three principles the rep should hold steady through every call. Honesty — never claim something the agency can't deliver, never inflate results, never tell the buyer something the rep wouldn't be comfortable being held to in twelve months. Loyalty — don't get poached by every shiny opportunity that walks past; stick with the campaign that's working long enough for it to compound. Integrity — recommend what the buyer actually needs, not what would generate the largest commission for the rep this month.

The reason these anchor principles matter operationally: they protect the rep from one of the most common career-ending mistakes — over-quoting a buyer who is naive enough to say yes. The over-quote feels like a big win this month. Twelve months later, the campaign hasn't delivered, the buyer is angry, the referrals dry up, and the agency loses both the renewal and the network the buyer would have brought. Integrity isn't a virtue — it's a long-game tactic. Reps who hold it close make more money over five years than reps who don't, by a wide margin.

"Don't over-quote. Don't under-quote. Get the right product for them — one you can sleep on at night. The deal isn't done at signing. It's done when five referrals have referred five more."

11. Grateful and mildly unsatisfied — the workweek rhythm

A note on emotional pacing. The reps were asked how they handle the rhythm of a five-day week. The model the session offered is two-stranded. First, gratitude — be aware of the things that are going well, the job that exists, the team that backs the rep, the roof and the meals and the relationships outside work. Carry that frame into Monday morning. Second, mildly unsatisfied — between Monday and Friday, choose a small thing to improve. One pitch line. One follow-up cadence. One small KPI to nudge upward.

Then on Friday: the pressure comes off. Pat yourself on the back. Acknowledge what worked. Then on Monday, restart the cycle. "Mildly unsatisfied" matters because it's the productive middle between complacency and self-flagellation. Complacent reps don't improve. Self-flagellating reps burn out. Mildly-unsatisfied reps compound.

"Be grateful. Be mildly unsatisfied. That's the position. Not depression, not complacency — that productive middle where you compound. End the week with a pat on your own back. Start the next week with a small new goal."

12. Action items for the team

1. Name the purpose of the call in the first sentence — "I'm calling about your SEO traffic" — to eliminate the selective-hearing window.
2. Stop chasing the silver bullet. There isn't one. Run the process; don't say dumb things. That's the whole game.
3. Label "I'm too busy" as ink, not data. Treat "I'll buy everything" the same way. Both are defensive moves. Stay on the process.
4. Build mid-morning and mid-afternoon "clean the boat" rituals into the daily schedule. Three-minute walks, glass of water, reset.
5. Start a one-page pattern log. Opening line / buyer reaction / what worked. Review weekly. Patterns become the rep's edge.
6. Walk away from dead calls faster. The deal is the thing chased — not the specific buyer on the line right now.
7. Practise the cheeky callback verbatim with a colleague before using it live. The tone is everything.
8. Quote every meeting at 5 minutes. End of story. The buyer needs the time to feel cheap.
9. End the week with one specific moment of gratitude AND one specific thing to nudge upward next week. Repeat.

THE RULE OF THUMB There is no perfect line. There is no silver bullet. There is a 147-kilowatt engine, and your job is to keep it running clean. Buyers will spray ink. Hose the boat down

between calls. Chase the deal, not the customer. The reps who last are the ones whose minds are still clean on call thirty.